Unit 5, Session 2: A birthday, a dance and a helping hand

Name: _____ Class: F / D Date: _____

Read first. Use the numbered paragraphs as evidence. Answer the exercises in English.

[1] What makes a birthday memorable: the food, the guests, or something unexpected? In the Chinese historical drama 甄嬛传, a birthday celebration gives us all three. The series first appeared in 2011. Its fictional palace world helps us discuss cultural traditions, personal relationships and the social importance of celebrations. A scene in Episode 13 shows how a happy occasion can become a difficult experience for one guest.

[2] The occasion is 温宜公主's first birthday. Members of the royal family and other palace guests gather for a banquet, a large formal meal. The celebration marks an important moment in the child's life. For her mother, 曹贵人, it is also a public occasion. The way people behave can show respect, friendship or a wish to impress someone powerful. A family event therefore has a wider social meaning.

[3] During the banquet, 曹贵人 asks 甄嬛 to perform the 惊鸿舞. This creates a problem because the dance is closely connected with the late 纯元皇后. Other people can compare the two women, so the request carries a political risk. 甄嬛 needs to respond carefully. 沈眉庄 plays music and 安陵容 sings while she dances. Their musical skills help turn a difficult request into a shared performance.

[4] Then 果郡王（允礼） joins the performance by playing the flute. His contribution helps 甄嬛 develop her dance. The result impresses the emperor. We can interpret his action as practical support: he uses something he can do to help someone in a difficult situation. The scene also invites an emotional response. What looks like one person's success depends partly on the choices and abilities of others.

[5] This royal birthday is different from a typical birthday party among classmates. It has formal behaviour and public expectations. However, the questions it raises may feel familiar. Who supports you when you feel nervous? Can a celebration strengthen a relationship? 温宜公主 is turning one, so this is not a coming-of-age ceremony. In the textbook article, a fifteenth birthday marks a change in a young person's social role. Both celebrations connect a personal milestone with a wider group.

[6] To connect the scene with your own life, think about someone who has supported you. You may have known that person since primary school or been friends for several years. Perhaps you have enjoyed the same music for a long time. A traditional celebration can honour a family custom; a simple gathering can celebrate a friendship. The most meaningful part may be the people who help us feel included.

Words for the scene: banquet = a large formal meal; flute = 笛子; milestone = an important stage or event.

Original teaching text based on Episode 13 of 甄嬛传. The final paragraph connects the scene to student life. The drama is fiction, not a historical record.

Class video: 温宜公主's birthday scene | Series information: LeTV

Reading and word families

A. Read and choose

Choose ONE answer for each question. Use the reading, not your memory of the drama.

1. What is the main idea of the reading?

   A. Royal celebrations always make every guest happy. B. A birthday scene shows how celebrations involve relationships and social roles. C. The reading explains every event in the drama.

2. What are the guests celebrating?

   A. 温宜公主's first birthday. B. 甄嬛's fifteenth birthday. C. 果郡王's return home.

3. Why is the dance request difficult for 甄嬛?

   A. The reading says she has never danced. B. The performance must last exactly one hour. C. People can compare her with the late 纯元皇后.

4. Which detail best supports the idea that success can depend on other people?

   A. The series first appeared in 2011. B. 沈眉庄 plays music, 安陵容 sings and 果郡王 plays the flute. C. 温宜公主 is one year old.

5. How long have 甄嬛 and 果郡王 known each other at this banquet?

   A. Exactly three months. B. Exactly five years. C. The reading does not say.

6. Which comparison is supported by paragraph 5?

   A. Both celebrations connect a personal milestone with a wider group. B. Both celebrations mark a girl becoming fifteen. C. Both celebrations require a royal family.

B. Build the adjective

Write the related adjective ending in -al. Check spelling; do not simply add -al to every noun.

Noun	Adjective	Noun	Adjective
7. music	_____	10. politics	_____
8. nature	_____	11. profession	_____
9. centre	_____	12. history	_____

Some words change spelling. Keep the adjective's meaning connected to the noun.

After class

Birthday scene
Watch the clip selected for this class
youtube.com/watch?v=SQqRMhbGPJE

Optional after-class reading
Chasing Dramas: Episode 13 - Princes and Dances
chasingdramas.com
Read one section. Find one example of support and one of competition.

More -al vocabulary

C. Choose from the word bank

Use each word ONCE. The practice situations on this page are imagined, not quotations or extra plot facts.

formal following official or polite rules; 正式的	**original** new and not copied; 原創的
royal connected with a king, queen or their family; 皇家的	**practical** useful in a real situation; 實際有用的
ceremonial used in or connected with a ceremony; 儀式的	**intentional** done on purpose; 故意的
fictional created for a story; 虛構的	**accidental** happening without a plan; 意外的

13. 甄嬛 writes a new poem for 果郡王 without copying anyone. It is an _____ poem.

14. 果郡王 offers a useful solution to 甄嬛's problem. His advice is _____.

15. 甄嬛 follows the official rules for dress and greetings. Her behaviour is _____.

16. The invitation is from the emperor's family. It is a _____ invitation.

17. 甄嬛 and 果郡王 are characters in a story. Their conversation is _____.

18. 果郡王 knocks over a cup without meaning to. The spill is _____.

19. 甄嬛 chooses her words carefully because she wants to send a message. Her choice is _____.

20. 甄嬛 wears a special robe only during an official ritual. It is _____ clothing.

D. Meaning and use

Choose ONE answer.

21. 甄嬛 feels very happy and starts to cry. Which word describes the moment?

A. emotional B. historical C. central

22. 果郡王 helps 甄嬛 in front of the other guests. This is a public action. A letter about his own feelings would be more ...

A. natural B. personal C. international

23. Which word means "passed down through customs over many years"?

A. original B. accidental C. traditional

24. Which sentence uses the adjective correctly?

A. 果郡王 gives 甄嬛 practice advice. B. 果郡王 gives 甄嬛 practical advice. C. 果郡王 gives 甄嬛 practically advice.

For / since and verb forms

for + a period: for three months. **since + a starting point:** since June / since we met.
For a continuing state: **have/has + past participle**. A finished event with a finished time uses the past simple.

All dates and durations in these grammar exercises are invented for practice; they are not the drama's timeline.

E. Choose for or since

25. 甄嬛 has lived here _____ two months. A. for B. since

26. 果郡王 has played the flute _____ he was a child. A. for B. since

27. 甄嬛 has not seen 果郡王 _____ last Friday. A. for B. since

28. 甄嬛 and 果郡王 have known each other _____ a long time. A. for B. since

29. 果郡王 has waited here _____ two hours. A. for B. since

30. 甄嬛 has enjoyed music _____ childhood. A. for B. since

31. 果郡王 has been away _____ three days. A. for B. since

32. 甄嬛 has felt more confident _____ the banquet. A. for B. since

F. Read the timeline and fill the gaps

Assume today is **1 September** of the same year. Use for, since or a number.

Situation	Starting point / last event	Now
甄嬛 and 果郡王 became friends.	1 June	They are still friends.
甄嬛 started studying dance.	1 May	She still studies dance.
果郡王 started playing the flute.	1 March	He still plays the flute.
甄嬛 last saw 果郡王.	25 August	She has not seen him again.

33. 甄嬛 and 果郡王 have been friends _____ 1 June.

34. They have been friends for _____ months.

35. 甄嬛 has studied dance _____ 1 May.

36. 果郡王 has played the flute for _____ months.

37. 甄嬛 has not seen 果郡王 _____ 25 August.

38. She has not seen him for _____ week.

G. Complete the verb forms

39. 甄嬛 _____ (know) 果郡王 since June.

40. 果郡王 _____ (be) her friend for three months.

41. How long _____ 甄嬛 _____ (live) here?

42. They _____ (meet) on 1 June.